

WHY IT WORKS

Unstructured communication forces the listener to organise your thoughts for you — a cognitive tax that creates frustration. PREP (Point, Reason, Evidence, Point) provides a complete logical arc that is easy to follow and easy to act on.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not a script to recite — it is a spine to hang natural language on.
- Not a way to sound clever — the structure serves the listener, not your image.
- It is a complete logical arc — point, reason, evidence, point — small enough to hold under pressure.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Ask them anything and you get an answer you can act on.

Principle: A structured answer is judged more competent than an unstructured one, even with identical content.

What you gain

- Answers that survive interviews, vivas and boardrooms
- A reputation for clear thinking
- Less rambling under nerves — the structure carries you
- Arguments that are easy to repeat to others
- A calm start to hard questions: you always know sentence one

Why most people fail at it

- They start with background and hope a point emerges.
- They give three weak reasons instead of one strong one.
- Their examples are hypothetical instead of lived.
- They forget the final restatement, so the answer trails off.

CORE FORMULA

Point -> Reason -> Evidence / Example -> Point (restate)

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before answering any important question, identify: what is my point? One reason. One example. Then restate the point.

BEST FOR

- Interview and viva-style questions
- Presentations and pitches
- Any situation where you need to structure a verbal argument
- Avoiding rambling when put on the spot

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Point — State the point first

Open with your actual position in one sentence. If you cannot name your point, you are not ready to answer — buy time honestly instead.

Buried: 'Well, there is a lot of context to this...'

Led: 'I think we should ship in March.'

2. Reason — Give the one strongest reason

Pick your best reason and give it alone. A single strong reason invites agreement; a list invites the listener to attack the weakest.

List: '...because of cost, and morale, and also competitors, and...'

One: 'The main reason: every month of delay costs us the January buyers.'

3. Example — Anchor it in something real

Use a specific, lived instance — named project, real numbers, actual outcome. Hypotheticals prove you can imagine; examples prove you have seen.

Hypothetical: 'Imagine if a customer churned because of this...'

Real: 'This is exactly why we lost the Hartley account in June.'

4. Point — Close the loop

Restate the point in fresh words. The restatement tells the listener the answer is complete — and it is the sentence they will remember.

Trailing off: '...so, yeah, that is kind of the situation.'

Closed: 'Which is why March is the right call.'

FIELD TIP

When your mind goes blank, PREP is the exit.

The structure is most valuable at the exact moment you feel least able to use it. Blanking on a hard question? Say your point — any defensible point — and the reason and example will queue up behind it.

Situation: Interviewer asks a question you did not prepare for.

Don't: 'Um, that is a really good question, I suppose there are lots of angles...'

Do: 'My honest answer is X. The reason I land there is Y. I saw it play out when Z.'

PHRASE BANK

PREP Phrases · Signalling the structure

- "My view is [Point]. The reason is [Reason]. For example, [Example]. So I would say [Point]."
- "I would answer that in two parts — the principle and the example."
- "Let me give you the direct answer, then the evidence."
- "Short version: [Point]. The reason I say that is [Reason]."
- "The way I think about it is: [Point] — and here is why."
- "I can answer that in one sentence and then give you a concrete example."
- "The point I want to make is [Point], because [Reason]."

Example Bridges · Moving to evidence

- "A concrete example of that is..."
- "The clearest instance I have seen was..."
- "In practice, this looks like..."
- "I can give you a recent example:"
- "That showed up clearly when..."

Mini-PREP · The structure at conversational size

- "Yes — because it saves us a week. We saw that on the last sprint. So yes."
- "I would skip it. Low turnout last time. Skip it."
- "Worth doing: cheap, fast, and it worked in March. So do it."
- "No — the numbers do not support it. They did not in Q2 either. Still no."
- "My take: go early. Early worked for the pilot. Go early."

PREP Under Pressure · Interviews, vivas and put-on-the-spot moments

- "Let me answer that directly, then give you my evidence."
- "My position has three parts: the claim, the reason, and what I saw that convinced me."
- "I will give you my conclusion first and then defend it."
- "That is a fair challenge — my answer is X, and here is the strongest case for it."
- "Give me ten seconds to structure this properly, because it deserves a clear answer."

Point Restaters · Closing the loop

- "So, coming back to where I started: X."
- "Which is exactly why I say X."
- "All of that points the same way: X."
- "So my answer stands: X."
- "That is the evidence — and it is why I hold the view."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Rambling answer with no clear point
Better: There are several factors involved here...
Best: My view is X. The reason is Y. The clearest example is Z. So: X.
2. Weak: Example without a point: 'Well, one time I did this thing...'
Better: Here is a relevant experience...
Best: State the point first. Then the example to back it.
3. Weak: Strong point, no evidence: 'I believe X.'
Better: I believe X, and I have seen evidence of it.
Best: Point, specific reason, concrete example, restate point.

DECISION TREE

If You are asked an open-ended question with no structure

Use PREP. State your point first.

"My view is... The reason I say that is..."

If You are rambling and losing your thread

Stop. Restate the point. Then give one reason.

"Let me come back to the main point — it is simply: ..."

If They are pressing for more than a point

Move to reason, then example.

"The reason I hold that view is X. A concrete example is Y."

If Your example is weak or vague

Use a specific, real situation — not a theoretical one.

"A real instance of that was..."

If You are using PREP too rigidly and it sounds mechanical

Keep the logic but vary the phrasing.

"I think X, and here is the best evidence I have for it."

SCENARIOS

Interview: 'Tell me about a challenge you have faced'

Point: the challenge. Reason: why it was hard. Example: what happened. Point: what you learned. — "The challenge was X. The reason it was difficult was Y. In practice, it looked like Z. What I took from it is..."

Meeting: 'What do you think we should do?'

State your recommendation. Give the main reason. Give one example. Restate. — "I think we should do X. The main reason is Y. We have seen that in Z. So my recommendation stands."

Pitch: making a case for your idea

Use PREP as the spine of each major point. — "The core argument is X. The evidence behind it is Y. A concrete example is Z. So: X."

Viva/oral exam: defending your work

Answer the examiner's question with PREP before expanding. — "My position is X. The theoretical basis is Y. My data showed Z. Which brings me back to X."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: Well, there's a lot to consider. The market is shifting and there's competing data and I think on balance, maybe, if conditions hold...

Manager: What are you actually recommending?

With the technique

You: My view is we should delay the launch. The main reason is market timing — Q3 data shows a 20% drop in category engagement. I'd recommend waiting until Q1.

Manager: Good, agreed. Let's set a Q1 target.

COMMON MISTAKES

Evidence before point

Sounds like: 'So last quarter this thing happened, and then another thing...'

Better: 'My conclusion is X. Last quarter is the evidence — here it is.'

Reason-stacking

Sounds like: 'There are seven reasons...'

Better: 'One reason above all: X. The others are supporting detail.'

The vague example

Sounds like: 'This kind of thing often happens in projects generally.'

Better: 'On the Meridian project, this exact failure cost us three weeks.'

No closing restatement

Sounds like: An answer that fades out after the example

Better: 'So: delay the launch. That is where the evidence points.'

PREP for everything

Sounds like: Structuring 'where shall we get lunch?' like a viva answer

Better: Save the full arc for questions that carry weight.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- Your answers feel structured and complete.
- People respond to your point directly rather than asking what you mean.
- Interviewers or audiences nod at the right moments.
- You feel more confident because you know where your answer is going.

Signs to adjust

- The structure sounds mechanical or too formulaic.
- Your examples are vague — 'in some situations' rather than a real case.
- You forget to restate the point at the end.
- You use PREP for simple questions that do not need it.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- In deeply emotional conversations where structure feels cold and clinical.
- In creative or brainstorming sessions where open-ended flow is more valuable than structured argument.
- When the relationship and context call for natural conversation rather than presentation mode.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'I am rambling — let me come back to the point, which is X.'

- "I am rambling — let me come back to the point, which is X."
- "Let me restart that answer with the conclusion first."
- "I gave you the example before the point. The point is X."
- "That was three weak reasons. The strong one is this."
- "Let me close the loop properly: my answer is X."

- "I lost my own thread — the question deserves a cleaner answer. Here it is."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Interview chain

PREP the answer -> stop -> invite the follow-up -> PREP the follow-up

My biggest strength is turning ambiguity into a plan. I have done it on every project that mattered — most recently the platform migration, where I turned a vague mandate into a six-week roadmap. That is the thing I reliably bring.

(Stop. Wait.)

Happy to go deeper on the migration if useful.

The short version: three workstreams, one owner each, shipped a week early.

Recommendation chain

PREP the case -> invite challenge -> answer the challenge -> next-step close

We should consolidate the two tools. It halves the licence cost, and the Bristol team already proved the workflow works. Consolidation is the move.

What would need to be true for you to disagree?

Fair point on migration risk — the Bristol rollout gives us the playbook for it.

If you are comfortable, I will scope the migration next week.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC003 — BLUF: Bottom Line Up Front

BLUF is the first quarter of PREP — when one sentence is enough, stop there.

TC008 — No-Overexplaining Discipline

No-Overexplaining Discipline is what keeps the structure from sprouting extra reasons.

TC026 — Decision Frame

Decision Frame structures the decision itself, where PREP structures your argument within it.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Identify the structure

In your next conversation, notice whether your answers have a clear point, reason, and example. Do not change anything yet.

Day 2 — Point first

In three answers today, state your position in the first sentence before explaining.

Day 3 — One reason

After making your point, give one specific reason. Not three reasons — one.

Day 4 — Concrete example

Practice attaching a concrete real-world example to one position you hold.

Day 5 — Restate the point

After each PREP answer, add the final sentence that restates your point.

Day 6 — Full PREP in practice

Use the full structure to answer one important question today.

Day 7 — Calibration

Did your answers feel clearer? Did people respond more directly? Did any structure feel forced?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I state my position (Point) in the first sentence?
- Did I give one clear reason — not a list of reasons?
- Did I use a concrete, specific example — not a hypothetical?
- Did I restate the point at the end?
- Did the structure feel natural — not mechanical?
- Did I avoid rambling past the example?
- Did the person I was speaking to seem to follow my argument clearly?